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PRESS RELEASE

Statistical indicators cannot bring about sustainable development unless they are tied to the social context, with existing welfare and rural development schemes brought together under one reference framework, finds report on SDG implementation in India

The above are among the key findings of a collaborative project established with the support of Queen Mary University of London and bringing together the Eco Foundation for Sustainable Alternatives (EFSA), National Law School of India University, O.P. Jindal Global University (JGU) and the Foundation for Global Governance and Sustainability (FOGGS). The project has just published its **report entitled "Implementing the SDGs in India: Poverty, Hunger and Gender"**.

The report is based on an analysis of the framework put in place by the Government of India to ensure implementation of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) endorsed by world leaders at the United Nations in September 2015 and applicable to all countries worldwide. **The report focuses on three of the 17 SDGs that are of particular importance to India**, namely:

- SDG1: End poverty in all its forms everywhere;
- SDG 2: Zero hunger; and
- SDG 5: Gender equality and empowerment of women and girls.

The overall aim is to map and assess the trajectory of sustainable development in India through the lens of SDG implementation. "This project has been an invaluable exercise in understanding and distinguishing between what is presented in reports and what is actually happening on the ground. It has helped us identify paths where further research and work is needed in order to achieve the 2030 Agenda," says report co-author Dr Stella Ladi, Senior Lecturer, Queen Mary University of London.

The report specifically reflects on the adequacy of SDG implementation methodologies and monitoring tools applied in the context of social, political, geographical and financial diversities in India. Among its key findings, the report notes that while the common SDG implementation framework does lend cohesion to efforts under way across India, ramifications of the exercise being anchored at the federal level may or may not be entirely relevant to all the 30 states and union territories of the country. Moreover, the rigour appears to be on data collection and monitoring rather than the end result, which indicates a substantial methodological failure – notably the reliance on statistical indicators which are not tied to the social context.

One major weakness appears to be the lack of training and sensitization of state/UT government officers about the SDGs and how the latter should become the reference framework for other schemes (panchayat, welfare schemes, rural development, etc.) that both reflect the SDGs and are vehicles for their realization. There is also a need to bring in a paradigm shift towards a rights-based approach to utilize the available resources for maximized impact.

Several recommendations included in the report regarding progress towards the fulfilment of SDGs 1,2 and 5 may be equally applicable to other SDGs in the Indian context and possibly beyond. For the SDGs to remain relevant for sustainable progress in India, a massive re-alignment exercise will have to be undertaken in full cognizance of the crisis precipitated by COVID-19.

Research results establish the initial basis for close collaboration between the Indian, British and EU partners involved, and are expected to be further strengthened through subsequent projects. "FOGGS is proud to have been associated with this project that advances work on identifying and bridging the gaps in SDG implementation at local, regional and national level with a view to fulfilling the promise of the 2030 Agenda in the Indian context that involves about one-sixth of humanity. We hope that the findings of the project will be put to good use in India and beyond," says Dr. Georgios Kostakos, FOGGS Executive Director and another one of the report's co-authors.

Following the publication of the report, the partners are planning a webinar to discuss its findings and possible steps forward. The webinar has been scheduled for Wednesday, 12 May 2021 at 11 am London time / 12 noon Brussels time / 3:30 pm Bangalore time. More information and a registration link will be shared at a later stage.

The report can be read/downloaded here.

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